

The MIRV system is equipped with indigenous avionics systems and high-accuracy sensor packages, ensuring that the re-entry vehicles reach their targets with the desired accuracy. Each warhead on the MIRV can be programmed to be released at different speeds with different trajectories to hit different targets that can be hundreds of kilometres apart. They can also be made to pound a single target several times with repeated strikes, thus leading to its annihilation.

Various telemetry and radar stations tracked the three MIRVs of Mission Divyastra. MIRV systems, with multiple warheads and divergent targets, each with its own separate flight path, make it difficult for air defence systems to detect, track, intercept and destroy them. MIRV-equipped missiles can also have decoys to outwit enemy defence systems.

For the DRDO, mastering its complicated mechanism has remained in the works along the evolution of the long-range Agni-V surface-to-surface nuclear-capable missile. Powered by a three stage, solid-fuelled engine, the MIRV equipped Agni-V is not just a technology demonstrator. It is primarily meant to provide nuclear deterrence against China. It is a crucial enabler of India's policy to have a 'credible minimum deterrence' that underpins the country's 'no first use' nuclear doctrine.

Agni I to IV missiles have ranges from 700 km to 3,500 km and have been inducted by the Strategic Forces Command, a component of India's Nuclear Command Authority. For the maiden MIRV flight of Mission Divyastra, the three warheads had been set a modest range of about 3,500 kms.

On March 7, India issued a NOTAM (Notice for Air Mission)—mandatory before a missile/rocket test—over the Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean Region (IOR). China is believed to have dispatched a second 'research vessel' towards the Bay of Bengal besides the one anchored off the Maldives, to glean sensitive information on the test. ■